

Seawall height in Ocean Ridge

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

OCEAN RIDGE • PALM BEACH COUNTY

5 ft NAVD88

New, substantially repaired or substantially rehabilitated seawalls in Ocean Ridge must have a top (including cap) of at least 5 ft NAVD88. Atlantic Ocean frontage is excluded.

The detail

MINIMUM	Top elevation incl. cap min 5 ft NAVD88 - Sec. 64-82(a)(1)
TRIGGER	New wall, work on more than 50% of shoreline length, or over 50% of replacement cost - Sec. 64-82(c)(5)
ALSO TRIGGERED	Substantial damage/improvement of the principal structure - Sec. 64-82(b)
EXCLUDED	Properties adjacent to the Atlantic Ocean - Sec. 64-82(f)
MAXIMUM	None set
CAP WIDTH	No more than 2 ft from the wet face or the property line, whichever is greater - Sec. 64-82(a)(4)
HOW FAR WATERWARD	Where the property line abuts the waterway line, a rebuilt wall may project at most 18 in. waterward, with no further projections - Sec. 64-82(a)(3)a
COST TEST	50% of fair market replacement cost as certified by a licensed Florida engineer; docks, piles and footers are excluded unless poured monolithically with the wall - Sec. 64-82(c)(5)
NAVIGATION AND EASEMENTS	Where the lot runs past the waterway line, a new or rebuilt wall may not unreasonably interfere with navigation or existing easement rights - Sec. 64-82(a)(2), (a)(3)b
NEGLECT	A seawall, bulkhead or dock left in disrepair or ruin so it causes flooding or damage is declared a public nuisance; failing to maintain is a citable violation under the town's community standards procedures - Sec. 64-81, 64-82(e)
NO WALLS ON EMPTY LOTS	A new seawall is not allowed where none existed and no principal structure exists, except to protect government property - Sec. 64-82(g)

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.